COMMERCIAL INFRASTRUCTURE

Would Your Website Get You Invited to Bid?

A referral gets your name into the conversation. Your website gives the next person something to judge.



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On Friday afternoon, an architect forwards your website to a property manager. You've worked with the architect before. She remembers your superintendent keeping the front entrance open while the crew replaced the lobby floor a few feet inside it. Now the property manager is lining up contractors for another lobby renovation. The building will stay open. She has to send her boss a shortlist on Monday.

She opens your portfolio. There's a good photograph of the finished lobby. She can see the terrazzo and the new reception desk. The question she has to answer for her boss is whether you know how to run the job around the people who still work there.

A service business website should explain the work you take on, show a comparable project, and make it easy to start a conversation about a specific assignment. The strongest project pages tell a buyer what the client needed to protect, what your firm was responsible for, and what you delivered. That gives the person forwarding the link a reason to put your name on the list.

What makes one project better evidence than another?

Choose the project that shares the buyer's hardest condition. Two jobs can look almost identical in a gallery and demonstrate different abilities. Start with what the buyer has to get right, then show the job that gives them a reason to believe you can do it.

Picture a Knicks fan coming back to Madison Square Garden for opening night. Now picture the arena operator who had to know which seats, restrooms, and entrances would be usable when the fans returned. In the 2010 filing naming Turner as construction manager, the Garden described a plan that closed the arena during the summers, kept it open for Knicks and Rangers seasons, and allowed some work to continue during those seasons. In 2013, the Garden reported completing the renovation after three consecutive off-season shutdowns. For a buyer with a fixed reopening date, the calendar is evidence. For the property manager in our opening, the next question is different. Could the building stay in use through the work, with fewer opportunities to shut it down? Madison Square Garden construction agreement summary · The Garden's 2013 completion announcement

Take two office projects from the same Dallas contractor, James R. Thompson. At **International Plaza III**, the work covered 27,000 square feet of amenity spaces. The contractor says it phased construction across five separately permitted areas and kept the building operational and occupied through nine months of work. BOKA Powell lists the lobby, coffee bar, training and meeting rooms, and fitness facilities in the program. It also names James R. Thompson as general contractor. Contractor's project account · Architect's project record

At **HBK's offices in The Union**, the same contractor describes fitting out 36,000 square feet across two floors in 18 weeks while the shell building was still under construction. The firm reports that HBK moved in on schedule and names its project manager and superintendent. If you're a tenant who's already told 200 people when they'll report to a new office, that's a project you'd want to ask about. The first question might be what the team did when something it needed from the base building ran late. Contractor's HBK project account

The buyer's concern	The project to send	What to ask next
A venue can close for scheduled windows and must reopen for a fixed calendar.	Madison Square Garden. The owner documented summer shutdowns and work continuing during the seasons.	Which parts had to reopen after each phase, and what could continue behind the scenes?
Tenants have to keep using the building during renovation.	International Plaza III. The contractor reports keeping the occupied building operational while working in phases.	How did the team agree on access and work hours with building management?
A tenant has a move-in date while the base building is still under construction.	HBK at The Union. The contractor reports handing over the fit-out in time for the tenant's scheduled move.	Which tasks depended on the base-building contractor, and how did the team handle delays?

James R. Thompson is an independent example drawn from public project records. NATA has no relationship with the firm.

Both Dallas projects would sit under "Commercial Interiors." The smaller job may be the better reference for our property manager. For the tenant with a move date, the other one may tell her more. If your sales team sends the same portfolio link for every inquiry, ask which of these buyers would know where to start.

What should the page actually say?

Put the condition that makes the job relevant beside the photograph. Here's how the International Plaza III page could open, using the published records.

> ### Renovating an office building that stayed open
>
> James R. Thompson was the general contractor for a 27,000-square-foot renovation of office amenities at International Plaza III in Dallas. The work covered five separately permitted areas. The building remained operational and occupied during construction.

That's a rewrite based on the case records, so it stops where they do. The account supports a conversation about phasing. A buyer would still have to ask about tenant access and how the contractor handled disruption. If you can publish an approved phase plan or share a reference who

saw the work happen, you can give that buyer a way to check the part that matters to them.

What does a buyer actually ask a contractor to prove?

A useful project page anticipates the buyer's questions about comparable work, the firm's responsibility, and how the work was carried out. A real request for qualifications can show you which of those questions buyers put in writing.

In 2024, the Orange County Library System in Florida sought firms for continuing construction management services. It asked for five comparable projects where the firm held the prime contract and the occupied facility or campus had to maintain normal operations during construction. It wanted references with firsthand knowledge of the firm's performance. It also said that a list of project elements without an explanation of how the work was performed would count against the submission. Orange County Library System RFQ 24-003, pp. 20–23

The library put in writing what a private buyer may ask informally. Who held the contract? What had to stay open? Who can tell me how it went? It also gave applicants a fictional branch renovation and asked them for a milestone schedule. Past work showed what the firm had handled before. The schedule would show how it thought about the library's own job. A project page can help a buyer reach that second conversation with a better question. The library's procurement required its own formal submission. Orange County Library System RFQ 24-003, pp. 21–24

Look at the last proposal your team wrote for the kind of work you want more of. Which paragraph did someone have to write from scratch to explain why your experience fit? If that same paragraph appears in three proposals, it's worth asking why the buyers only see it after they've invited you.

What changes when the buyer is hiring for design judgment?

A design project should show a decision the team made under a real constraint. Tell the reader what needed to change, what the client wanted to preserve, and what the team did when those goals had to be met together. Use a photograph, plan, or client account that lets the reader examine the choice.

The Ford Foundation needed to bring its Manhattan headquarters up to updated city safety codes. It considered relocating, then chose to renovate the landmark with Gensler leading the design. The foundation wanted the building to welcome more people while preserving its original character. Its COO, John Bernstein, gave a specific account of what that meant in the atrium garden. The team removed steps, changed levels and installed a lift. The garden reopened to the public. Ford Foundation's account of the renovation · Bernstein's interview, pp. 26–27 · Ford Foundation's building history

An atrium photograph can show a garden that still feels like the garden people remember. Bernstein's account tells a different part of the story. A person who couldn't use the old route has another way through. If you're hiring an architect to adapt a building people already care about, you can now ask how the team decided where to alter the original fabric. That's a question about the service you're buying.

For a smaller practice, the same idea might belong in a single caption. If you show a kitchen where the client needed to keep the existing floor, say where you moved the island, what that saved the client from replacing, and who determined the new layout. Verify those details against the drawings or the project lead's account. The person who loved the photograph can now see the kind of judgment they might hire you for.

Should you rewrite one project page or redesign the whole site?

Start with the point where the buyer loses the information they need. Rewrite a project page when the evidence is missing there. Change the navigation or the service page when people can't find evidence you already have. Consider a broader redesign when several important services have the same problem and the current site makes it hard to show or maintain the right information.

Ask a buyer or someone who regularly recommends firms like yours to try this on a phone. Use a real brief with identifying details removed. Give them the link your team usually sends and ask them to write the sentence they'd put above it when forwarding it to a colleague. Ask them to point to the line that backs up their recommendation. Save the actual response.

Three answers that point to different fixes.

- **"I found three lobbies. I still don't know if you've worked around tenants."** Rewrite one project page using a documented constraint and your role. Give the revised page to another reader with the same brief.
- **"That occupied renovation is exactly what we need. I only saw it after you sent me the link."** Give the service page a direct route to the project and label it in the buyer's language. Repeat the test from the service page.
- **"I understood the case. I sent a message about a May start and the person who called asked me to explain the job again."** Submit a test inquiry and follow it to the person who replies. Check whether the job details survive the handoff and who covers when that person is away.

Those answers are examples of what to listen for. Compare what readers can find and explain before and after one change. If you also track the business outcome, record whether an inquiry mentioned a comparable job or led to a scoping call or bid invitation. A change in those numbers is a reason to investigate. Referral volume, the type of work coming in, and seasonality can change them too.

The case for rebuilding gets clearer when the same finding turns up across the business. Suppose you've grown from tenant fit-outs into renovations of occupied buildings, and both services still lead to a single photo gallery. Your team has to explain the distinction on every call. If a revised case helps buyers understand one service, try giving each service its own page and its own set of projects. A larger investment makes sense if the site can't support that structure, or if the people who finish the jobs have no practical way to keep the cases current. The brief for the rebuild can then name what buyers need to find and who will keep it accurate.

The same project page can serve someone who starts in Google. Put the project facts in readable text and link to the case from the relevant service page. For example, someone searching for office renovations in occupied buildings can land on a page that says which building stayed open and who held the contract. Google recommends the same search fundamentals for its AI features, including making important content available as text. Google Search Central guidance

Go back to the architect's Friday email. By Monday morning, the property manager needs one sentence she can put in front of her boss. "They've renovated an occupied office building in phases. Let's ask how they'd handle our lobby." What page would you send her today?

Frequently asked questions

What if we can't name the client or show the work?

Agree on what you can disclose. An approved description can still cover the building type, your role and a constraint you handled. If those details would identify the client, use another project publicly and discuss references through the channels the client permits.

Can we include a project our founder did at a previous firm?

Credit the firm that held the contract, describe the founder's own role and check what you have permission to show. Put the experience in the founder's bio or label it clearly alongside company work. The buyer can then ask which people and capabilities carry over to their project.

What should we track after improving a project page?

Record whether relevant buyers mention or share the case, whether their inquiries contain enough context to act on, and whether those conversations progress. Keep the counts alongside the period, project type and referral source where known. That makes it easier to tell what's worth testing next.

The opening and the sample buyer responses are illustrative. The project examples are drawn from the public records linked above.